

Maya for Marx

The Left-Mayawati political romance not only revives the Third Front, but has the potential to get the numbers to challenge the UPA and NDA in the race for power



SIPRA DAS

■ By Shafi Rahman

Amidst the dust and din of the trust vote, the past week offered a snapshot of a big-ticket political alliance. A coalition of 10 parties, led by the BSP leader and Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Mayawati, after losing out the first lap in the race for numbers game in Parliament, is pausing to plan its political destiny.

Last week, when CPI(M) General Secretary Prakash Karat drove up to Mayawati, he instilled life into the United National Progressive Alliance (UNPA), which was in deathbed following the Samajwadi Party's (SP) decision to support the UPA Government at the Centre.

Now Team Maya is going beyond the photo-ops with an impressive line-up, raring to make a nation-wide presence. On July 23, the last meeting of this newly-formed alliance was attended by Karat, A.B. Bardhan and D. Raja (CPI), H.D. Deve Gowda (JD-S), G. Devarajan (Forward Bloc), Abani Ray (RSP), Ajit Singh (RLD), N. Chandrababu Naidu (TDP), K. Chandrashekhar Rao (TRS), Ajay Chautala (INLD) and Babulal Marandi (Jharkhand Vikas Morcha).

"We have decided to launch a national-level campaign on price rise, farmers' suicide, Indo-US nuclear deal, rise of communal forces, and gross misuse of governmental agencies like the CBI to harass political leaders," says Mayawati. The 10-